EXTREME WINNERS

In Punjab and J&K, embers from a turbulent past burn bright again at the hustings



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

AMRITPAL SINGH SANDHU, *31*

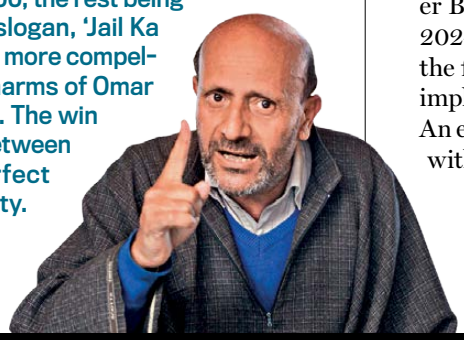
| INDEPENDENT | *Khadoor Sahib, Punjab*

He popped up seemingly out of nowhere, a face with no history, attired like Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, invoking the slain terrorist, and talking his talk. That was all the historical resonance Punjab needed, or at least those disillusioned with the void in the formal panthic space. Open advocacy of Khalistan, calling his Indian passport a mere "travel document", a headline-grabbing raid on a police station in Ajnala with the Guru Granth Sahib as shield, a dramatic 20-day chase, a surrender at Bhindranwale's Rode village...it had already been a whirlwind ride before he won by Punjab's highest margin, 197,120 votes. Amritpal's NSA imprisonment at Dibrugarh has been extended by a year, so it must have been a curious spectacle, the non-believer's swearing-in on July 5.

SHEIKH ABDUL 'ENGINEER' RASHID, *57*

| INDEPENDENT | *Baramulla, J&K*

Groomed in Abdul Ghani Lone's pro-azadi People's Conference, 'Engineer' Rashid—so called for his decade with the state public works corporation—was a "people person" whose street cred helped him win state elections in 2008 and 2014. In the 2019 LS poll, he stood third from Baramulla. That chaotic August, Rashid became one of a long list of political prisoners: with terror funding charges against him, he'll soon complete five years in Tihar. The 2024 poll campaign was anchored by son Abrar for just Rs 27,000, the rest being community-funded. His slogan, 'Jail Ka Badla Vote Se', proved far more compelling than the moderate charms of Omar Abdullah and Sajjad Lone. The win also showed up the gap between New Delhi's picture-perfect claims and Kashmir's reality.



SARABJIT SINGH KHALSA, *47*

| INDEPENDENT | *Faridkot, Punjab*



Unlike Amritpal, Sarabjit's credentials are inherited. As the son of Indira Gandhi's assassin Beant Singh, he ran for the Lok Sabha thrice before but couldn't repeat the 1989 triumphs of grandfather Sucha Singh (Bathinda) and mother Bimal Kaur (Ropar). But 2024 has proved propitious, with Amritpal watering the fields next door in Khadoor Sahib, the Akalis in implosion mode, and the AAP racked by factionalism. An enthused Sarabjit is now talking of a new Akali Dal, with the kin of other slain Sikh militants.

–Anilesh S. Mahajan